

Killer rigs

We tell you about the best components to look for various PC rigs at different budgets.

Recommended buys

The very best products you can buy right now spanning across 10 popular tech categories. Have a fun time buying!

VR Headsets

To induce headache and nausea or not?

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In all my time exploring the length and breadth of consumer technology products and services, I've come across many self-professed "revolutionary" breakthroughs in technology. The most recent one that comes to mind is how stereoscopic 3D in televisions was going to be the next best thing in home entertainment. The marketers got that one wrong, obviously, as close to four years on and 3D TVs have still not caught consumer interest. VR, on the other hand, looks a lot more promising for two main reasons: it's a whole new product category with SKUs at affordable prices.

VR-driven products are being announced and launched thick and fast. A lot of the hero products, the flag bearers of VR – the Oculus Rift and HTC Vive VR – have still not launched in the market. But already there's a flurry of activity from content providers in the form of VR-enabled games (Steam) and 360-degree videos (Facebook, Google, etc). And as expected, OEMs and startups are hastily trying to launch their products in the market.

Apart from the Oculus Rift, which I've had a chance to try every year since 2013, and HTC Vive VR, which I experienced a few months earlier, everything else has been second best as far as a full-blown, immersive, 360-degree VR experience is concerned. Both the Oculus Rift and HTC Vive are VR headsets that need a pretty powerful PC to pump in specially created content. While both products haven't yet started selling in the market, they're the best that VR has to offer for all early adopters and well worth the wait. Apart from creating a highly immersive environment, the biggest challenge for any VR headset is to make the wearer feel as comfortable

as possible, and these two headsets from Oculus and HTC are the only ones that have managed to overcome a substantial amount of these two obstacles. They're by no means perfect, but it's the best the industry has to offer for any enthusiast at the moment.

I've also tried out Tesseract (another VR headset) from Absentia VR, a company started by a bunch of BITS Pilani dropouts. Their solution is also PC-powered, converting 2D content into stereoscopic 3D, and I tried an FPS game on it, among other things. This device was a notch below the Oculus and HTC Vive, in my books, but from the prototype I first tried in November to Tesseract's latest iteration which sells for ₹20k and supports 1440p, the quality has improved substantially and if you want to try a local brand, then be sure to give this a try.

What about Microsoft HoloLens? Well, I recently had a chance to try it out in a developer's expo in Boston and I definitely liked what I saw. However, Microsoft has only just started releasing a development kit of the device, which is priced at a whopping US \$3000 (or approx. ₹1.9 lac), which just makes it an extremely niche product that will only attract very

few customers to begin with. I think you shouldn't hurry to pick this one up, just yet. It's a good thing that it isn't available for customers outright. Hah!

Then there are a bunch of mobile VR headsets that have started flooding the market. VR headsets that essentially let you place your smartphone in the headset and you watch 360-degree videos and other content off of it – it doesn't need a PC connection of any sort. You'll see them being sold on Amazon, Flipkart, Ebay, Snapdeal, and other ecommerce platforms online. Just how good or bad are these early mobile VR headsets?

Well, the only "good" mobile VR headset I've tried so far is the Samsung Gear VR, but even that suffers from slight pixelation and only supports select Samsung Galaxy smartphones. Other attempts from companies like Converge VR (from Mumbai), Proculus VR, etc., are trying to undercut the expensive mobile VR headsets by offering sub-₹10k and sub-₹5k headsets. I've received both of them, and a few others which aren't worth mentioning, and these attempts all but harden my conclusion on mobile VR headsets at the moment. Stay away from them, they're not worth the money! 

